

ANCIENT INDIA: MAJOR ARCHAEOLOGICAL BREAKTHROUGHS (UPDATE: 2026 PRELIMS)

ABHISHA AI
BY ABHISHEK PATHAK

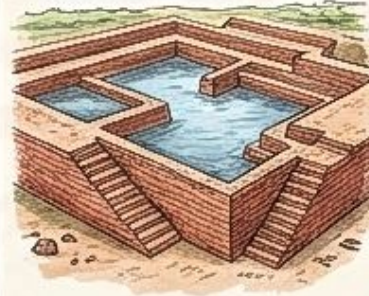
1 REDEFINING THE INDIAN IRON AGE



- **Focus:** ADICHCHANALLUR, SIVAGALAI, THELUNGANUR (Tamil Nadu).
- **Key Discovery:** Iron objects dated to 2953 BCE - 3345 BCE (using AMS dating).
- **Impact:** Pushes the Iron Age significantly earlier in India than 1200 BCE. Contradicts "Diffusionist Theory" (westward origin).
- **UPSC Insight:** Suggests independent origin of metallurgy in South India; contemporaneous with IVC's Copper-Bronze Age.

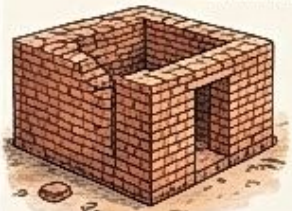


2 HARAPPAN WATER MANAGEMENT UPDATES



- **Site:** RAKHIGARHI (Haryana). Linked to Indus-Saraswati system.
- **Findings:** Discovery of a massive reservoir in Mound 3 & 4 (2024-2026 excavations).
 - Multi-chambered with brick steps. Sophisticated drains.
- **Context:** Rakhigarhi is now the largest Harappan site.
 - The reservoir matches Dholavira's engineering.
 - Shows high adaptability to plains terrain.
- **2026 Connection:** Budget 2026 allocation for "Iconic Site" development.

KEEZHADI: URBAN CONTINUITY



- **Site:** Keezhadi, Sivagangai district, Tamil Nadu (Vaigai Valley).
- **Chronology:** Dated to 6th Century BCE, linking it to the Sangam Era and Second Urbanization (Gangetic Plains).
- **Evidence:** High literacy indicated by Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions on pottery. Weaving industry (spindle whorls), dyeing vats, glass beads.
- **Feature:** Appears to be a highly secular settlement; no major religious structures found yet.



KEY SITE COMPARISON

Site	Primary Material	Water System	Timeline	Major Highlight
Dholavira (Gujarat)	Stone (Rock-cut)	Check Dams & connected Reservoirs	Mature Harappan (2600 BCE)	UNESCO Site
Rakhigarhi (Haryana)	Mud-brick & Baked Brick	Massive Reservoirs & detailed Drains	Early to Late Harappan	Largest IVC Site DNA Study
Keezhadi (TN)	Baked Bricks & Ring Wells	Terracotta Ring Wells & Industrial Drainage	Sangam Age (6th BCE - 1st CE)	Link: IVC & Sangam culture

POINTS TO REMEMBER FOR PRELIMS

- ✓ Site-River mapping.
- ✓ Rakhigarhi's development and exclusions.

- ✓ Indigenous development of Iron Metallurgy in South India.

- ✓ Rakhigarhi's status and funding.
- ✓ Keezhadi's secular character and early literacy.

LAKHAPAR & BAHAJ: BRIDGING THE HARAPPAN-VEDIC GAP

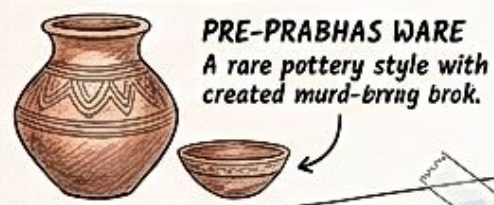
LAKHAPAR, GUJARAT: EARLY HARAPPAN SETTLEMENT
(c. 5300 YBP/3300 BCE)



KEY DISCOVERY:
HARAPPAN HABITATION CONTEXT



UNIQUE CERAMICS



MATERIALS & TRADE



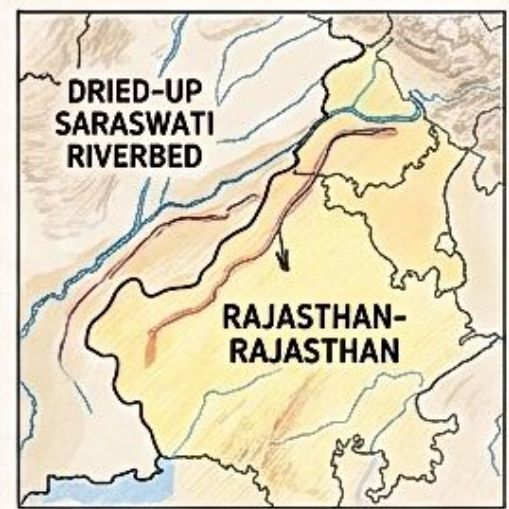
ECONOMY



THE MISSING LINK

Connects known burial sites to actual settlement location.

BAHAJ VILLAGE, RAJASTHAN: THE SARASWATI CONNECTION



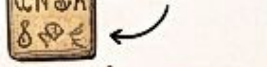
STRATIGRAPHIC TIMELINE
(23 METERS DEEP!)

- KUSHAN/GUPTA (c. 1st-6th CE)
- Temple evidence
- MAHAJANAPADA/MAURYAN (c. 6th-3rd BCE)
- NBP Ware, Early Brahmi
- VEDIC TRANSITION (c. 1500-1000 BCE)
- PAINTED GREY WARE (PGW), OCHRE COLOURED POTTERY (OCP)
- LATE HARAPPAN (c. 1900-1500 BCE)
- EARLY HARAPPAN (c. 3300-2600 BCE)
- Microliths, early pottery

KEY FIND:
IS YA3NA-KUNDAS
(Fire Altars)



SEALS WITH
EARLY BRAHMI
SCRIPT



Shiva-Parvati
terracotta idols
Transition from Vedic
fire rituals to
Puranic Hinduism

- KUSHAN/GUPTA TIMELINE (c. 1st-6th CE)
- Temple evidence
- MAHAJANAPADA/MAURYAN (c. 6th-3rd BCE)
- NBP Ware, Early Brahmi
- VEDIC TRANSITION (c. 1500-1000 BCE)
- PAINTED GREY WARE (PGW), OCHRE COLOURED POTTERY (OCP)
- LATE HARAPPAN (c. 1900-1500 BCE)
- EARLY HARAPPAN (c. 3300-2600 BCE)
- Microliths, early pottery



COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS FOR PRELIMS

	LAKHAPAR	BAHAJ
FOCUS	Mudappan habitations	Shiva-Parvati idols
RIVER	Dry riverbed	Paleochannel
POTTERY	Pare-pottery	Printed-rayond pottery
RITUAL EVIDENCE	Ritual evidence	Transition from Vitual evidence

UPSC CSE PRELIMS 2026: MEGALITHIC DISCOVERIES (News & Updates)

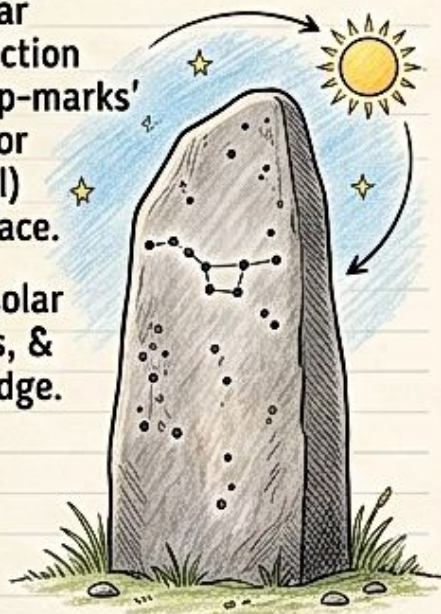
KEY MEGALITHIC SITES & SIGNIFICANCE



1. MUDUMAL VILLAGE, TELANGANA



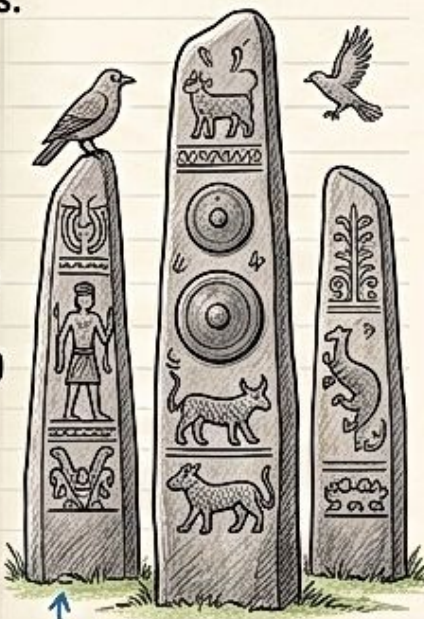
- **RECENT STATUS:** Added to UNESCO Tentative List (March 2025)
- **SIGNIFICANCE:**
 - Largest Megalithic Burial Site in South India (80 acres)
 - Archaeo-astronomical Observatory (approx. 3,500-4,000 years old)
 - Earliest known star constellation depiction in South Asia: 'Cup-marks' forming Ursa Major (Saptarshi Mandal) on a flat menhir face.
 - Shows advanced solar calendar, solstices, & equinoxes knowledge.
- **STRUCTURES:**
 - ~80 Menhirs,
 - ~3,000 Alignment Stones.



2. LIANPUI MENHIRS, MIZORAM



- **RECENT STATUS:** Declared Monument of National Importance (July 2025)
- **SIGNIFICANCE:**
 - Second site in Mizoram after Vangchhia (Kawtchhuah Ropui).
 - Intricately carved, showing pre-Christian Mizo cultural motifs.
 - **COMMEMORATIVE:** Erected for clan achievements in hunting or combat (Lunghun Ropui).
 - Potential link to the lost Vangchhia Civilization (ca. 600 CE).
- **MOTIFS:** Human figures, birds, animals, mithun heads, gongs, lizards.



LUNGPHUN ROPUI

3. MALAMPUZHA DAM, KERALA



- **RECENT STATUS:** Major ASI discoveries near reservoir (early 2025)
- **SIGNIFICANCE:**
 - One of Kerala's largest megalithic complexes (~110 structures, 45 hectares).
 - High variety of burial types in one area, suggesting social stratification.
 - Exhibits transition from using Granite to Laterite stones.
- **TYPES:** CISTS (stone boxes), DOLMENS (stone tables), URN BURIALS, STONE CIRCLES.



CIST



DOLMEN



URN



CIRCLE OF STONES



PRELIMS TIP

Iron Age, Black & Red Ware pottery, Iron Tools, Grave Goods.



INDIA'S RECENT UNESCO RECOGNITIONS (2025)

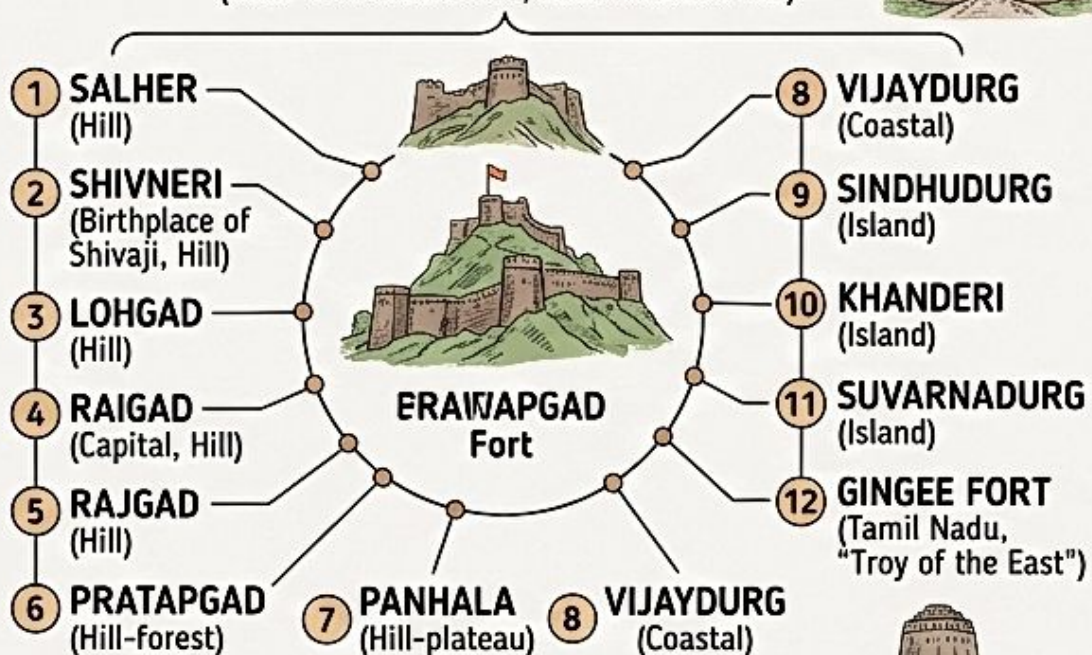
1. WORLD HERITAGE LIST (TANGIBLE)

MARATHA MILITARY LANDSCAPES

DATE: JULY 2025 (47th WH Committee Session, Paris)

TOTAL SITES: 12 FORTS (11 MAHARASHTRA, 1 TAMIL NADU)

DESCRIPTION: UNIQUE INDIGENOUS MILITARY ARCHITECTURE
(17th-19th CENTURIES, MARATHA EMPIRE)



KEY NOTE: INDIA'S 44th WORLD HERITAGE SITE.
Inscribed under Criteria (iv) and (vi).



2. INTANGIBLE CULTURAL HERITAGE (ICH)

DEEPAVALI



DECEMBER 2025
(20th Session, New Delhi)

INDIA'S 16th ELEMENT on
Representative List of Humanity

INCLUSIVE CHARACTER,
UNITY IN DIVERSITY

VICTORY OF LIGHT
OVER DARKNESS

LIVING HERITAGE,
GENERATIONAL TRANSMISSION



ONGOING EFFORTS:

- CHHATH PUJA
- Traditional Indian Diet/Ayurvedic food practices

3. MEMORY OF THE WORLD (MoW) REGISTER

ANCIENT MANUSCRIPTS

DATE: APRIL 2025

A

SHRIMAD BHAGAVAD GITA

- Part of Bhishma Parva, Mahabharata
- Synthesizes Vedic, Buddhist, Jain philosophies
- Global ethical, spiritual influence

B

BHARAT MUNI'S NATYASHASTRA

- Treatise on Performing Arts (Dance, Drama, Music)
- Codifies Rasa & Abhinaya
- Called 'Fifth Veda'

LOCATION



Preserved at **BHANDARKAR ORIENTAL RESEARCH INSTITUTE (BORI), PUNE**

QUICK REFERENCE TABLE (2025) FOR 2026 ASPIRANTS

UNESCO CATEGORY	LATEST INSCRIPTION (2025)	TOTAL COUNT (INDIA)
World Heritage (Tangible)	Maratha Military Landscapes	44
Intangible Heritage (ICH)	Deepavali	16
Memory of the World	Bhagavad Gita & Natyashastra	13+

PRELIMS POINTER: BEWARE: ONLY GINGEE FORT (Maratha Military Landscapes) is in **TAMIL NADU**; rest are in **MAHARASHTRA**.
Watch for statement-based questions.

ABHISHA AI
by Abhishek Pathak



UPSC PRELIMS 2026: UNESCO TENTATIVE LIST UPDATES (JAN 2025 - APR 2026)



OFFICIAL NOMINATION FOR 2025-26 CYCLE



SARNATH (Ancient Buddhist Site)

KEY FEATURES & SIGNIFICANCE

- Site of Buddha's First Sermon (Dhammachakkappavattana Sutta)
- Major Historical/Archaeological hub
- Under Tentative List since 1998

PRINCIPAL MONUMENTS



- Dhamek Stupa**
- massive solid cylindrical structure



- Chaukhandi Stupa**
- Octagonal Tower
 - Built by Akbar's general Govardhan



- Ashoka Pillar**
- Lion Capital Nationally, National Emblem

*: Only one site nominated for full inscription annually

NEW NATURAL SITES ON TENTATIVE LIST (Sep 2025)



STATE	Maharashtra	Karnataka	Meghalaya	Nagaland	Andhra Pradesh	Kerala	Andhra Pradesh
SITE NAME & TYPE	Deccan Traps (Flood Basaltic Province)	St. Mary's Island (Columnar Basaltic Lava)	Meghalayan Age Caves (focus from Mawmluh Cave) (urduia iontowoch cave)	Erra Matti Dibbalu (Red Sand Dunes)		Varkala Cliffs (Cenozoic Sedimentary Cliffs)	Tirumala Hills Natural Arch (Silathoranam)
GEOLOGICAL / HISTORICAL IMPORTANCE	One of largest volcanic features on Earth (~66 million years old)	Exhibits rare columns; evidence of break-up of Greater India from Madagascar	Mawmluh speleothems helped define the current global geological time unit 'Meghalayan Age'	Coastal red sediment mounds near Visakhapatnam; Geo-heritage site		Only such cliffs along Arabian Sea; unique sedimentary sequence	Rare natural geological arch, millions of years old

REAL-TIME UPDATES & STRATEGY TIP



CURRENT STATUS (as of April 2026)

- Total World Heritage Sites in India: 45 (after 2025 inscription of Maratha Military Landscapes)
- Sites on Tentative List: ~69
- Next planned nomination (2026-27): Living Root Bridges (Meghalaya)

UPSC PRELIMS STRATEGY

- Focus on specific geological periods (Cretaceous for Deccan, Holocene/Meghalayan for Caves)
- Match sites with states and unique features (e.g., Octagonal tower, Columnar basalt)
- Nodal agencies: ASI for cultural, WII for natural sites



'UPSC 2026: RELIGIOUS & CULTURAL TRADITIONS | LIVE UPDATES

MAHA KUMBH MELA 2025 (PRAYAGRAJ)

Held from Jan-Feb 2025 at the Triveni Sangam (Ganga, Yamuna, mythical Saraswati)

- 'Maha Kumbh' occurring every 12 years

SHAHI SNAN DATES (Feb 3)

Makar Sankranti Mauni Amavasya Basant Panchami

Inscribed on UNESCO Representative List of Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity (2017)

- 'DIGITAL KUMBH' & ecological focus

BUDDHA SAMYAK DARSHAN MUSEUM (VAISHALI)

Inaugurated in July 2025

- Built entirely of stone to last 2,500 years
- Houses 'Sacred Mud Relics' (discovered 1958-62)



SIGNIFICANCE OF VAISHALI

- Second Buddhist Council
- Buddha's last sermon
- Site of the Licchavis' Relic Stupa



BUDDHIST DIPLOMACY & RELICS EXPOSITION

- Relics of Lord Buddha (from Piprahwa) sent to VIETNAM, RUSSIA, & BHUTAN in 2025



PIPRAHWA RELICS (Discovery 1898)

- Stone coffer with early Brahmi inscription, identifying so much them as Buddha's ashes
- Historic repatriation of relics to National Museum (July 2025)



REAL-TIME HERITAGE UPDATES (2025-26)

- DEEPAVALI added to UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage List (Dec 2025)
- GYAN BHARATAM MISSION launched for digitizing manuscript legacy
- CHHATH MAHAPARV nominated for the 2026-27 cycle





MAJOR HISTORICAL CENTENARIES FOR UPSC PRELIMS 2026

FOR UPSC PRELIMS 2026



1. 150 YEARS OF VANDE MATARAM (1875 - 2025/2026)



- ✓ **COMPOSED BY:** Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay in 1875. Published in 'Bangadarshan'. ★ ★
- ✓ **LITERARY CONTEXT:** Included in famous novel '*Anandamath*' (1882), set against the Sanyasi Rebellion.
- ✓ **POLITICAL DEBUT:** First sung by Rabindranath Tagore at the 1896 Calcutta Session of Indian National Congress (INC). ★ ★ ★
- ✓ **FREEDOM STRUGGLE:** Key role in Swadeshi Movement (1905), "anthem of resistance."
- ✓ **CONSTITUTIONAL STATUS:** Adopted as National Song on Jan 24, 1950, equal status to National Anthem.
- ✓ **TRANSLATION:** Translated to English by Sri Aurobindo as "Mother, I bow to thee."

★ ★ Year-long commemoration: Nov 7, 2025, to Nov 7, 2026



2. 350TH MARTYRDOM ANNIVERSARY OF GURU TEGH BAHADUR (NOV 2025)



- ✓ Known as "Hind di Chadar" (Shield of India). 9th Sikh Guru. ★ ★
- ✓ **SACRIFICE:** Executed in 1675 in Delhi under orders of Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb for resisting forced conversions of Kashmiri Pandits.
- ✓ **SACRED SITES:**
 - Gurdwara Sis Ganj Sahib (Delhi): Execution site.
 - Gurdwara Rakab Ganj Sahib (Delhi): Cremation site.
- ✓ **THEOLOGICAL CONTRIBUTION:** 115 hymns in Guru Granth Sahib. Founded city of Chakk Nanaki (Anandpur Sahib).
- ✓ **2025 COMMEMORATION:** Massive 'Gurbani Kirtans' & exhibitions at Anandpur Sahib by Government and SGPC.



3. 107TH ANNIVERSARY OF JALLIANWALA BAGH (APRIL 13, 2026)



- ✓ Baisakhi Day, April 13, 1919. Peaceful crowd protesting arrest of Dr. Saifuddin Kitchlew & Dr. Satyapal under Rowlatt Womt under Rowlatt Act ("Black Act").
- ✓ **THE INCIDENT:** General Dyer ordered troops to fire on unarmed crowd. 
- ✓ **KEY CONSEQUENCES:**
 - Rabindranath Tagore renounced Knighthood.
 - Mahatma Gandhi gave up Kaiser-i-Hind title.
 - Hunter Commission formed to investigate.
 - Udham Singh assassinated Michael O'Dwyer in 1940. ★
- ✓ **2026 CONTEXT:** Recent renovations sparked debates on "heritage preservation vs. modern aesthetics," potential theme for GS Paper 1.



GI TAGS & CRAFT HERITAGE

(Updated: EARLY 2026)

1. ODISHA: TRIBAL HERITAGE & FRAGRANT RICE

→ Kapdaganda Shawl (Handicraft):

- Woven by Dongria Kondh (PVTG)
- Designs represent Niyamgiri Hills, sacred abode.
- Off-white coarse cotton, red, yellow, brown threads.



→ Lanjia Saura Painting (Handicraft):

- Lanjia Saura (PVTG)
- 'Idital' / 'Ekons' wall murals.
- White stone/lime paste on red-ochre background.



→ Koraput Kala Jeera Rice (Agricultural):

- "Prince of Rice"
- Black grains, distinct aroma, high nutritional value.
- Traditional cultivation in Koraput.



INDIA SURPASSES 650+ REGISTERED GI TAGS

2. ASSAM: NEO-VAISHNAVITE TRADITIONS (Rooted in Sattriya Culture & Srimanta Sankardeva)

→ Majuli Masks (Mukha):

- From Sattras of Majuli (largest river island)
- Used in Bhaona (theatre) for Ramayana/Mahabharata characters.



→ Majuli Manuscript Painting:

- Hand-painted on Sanchi Pat (Agar tree bark)
- Illustrates religious texts (e.g., Adya Dasama)



3. UTTAR PRADESH: CULTURAL & AGRO-DIVERSITY

→ Chiraigaon Karonda (Agricultural):

- Pink fruit (Bengal Currant), Varanasi.
- High Iron & Vitamin C.



→ Banaras Mural Painting (Handicraft):

- Traditional wall paintings in Varanasi temples & akharas.
- Spiritual themes, local life.



→ Banaras Lal Peda (Foodstuff):

- Famous sweet
- Roasted milk solids (khoa), cardamom, saffron.



UPSC QUICK-FACTS TABLE

Legal Framework:
GI of Goods Act, 1999
(effective 2003)

Nodal Body:
Office of Controller General of
Patents, Designs and Trademarks

Validity:
10 Years
(Renewable)

International Link:
Governed by TRIPS (WTO),
(WTO), Paris Convention

Top State (2026):
Tamil Nadu (followed
by UP & Karnataka)

UPSC PRELIMS 2026: INDIA'S CULTURAL HERITAGE UPDATE (2025-26)

I. REPATRIATION & ACQUISITIONS (2025)



Piprahwa Gems

- From British citizen, July 2025, after 127 years.
- Buddhist relics from 1898 excavation in UP.
- Unique Public-Private Partnership involving Ministry of Culture and Godrej Industries Group.



Bhosale Sword

- Historic sword of Raghuji Bhosale I, acquired from overseas auction in April/August 2025. Firangi-style blade, Mulheri basket hilt, hilt, Devanagari inscription.
- Expanded Maratha influence.

II. GYAN BHARATAM PORTAL (LAUNCHED 2025)



- Digital Platform for Manuscripts
- Goal: Digitize & provide access to >1 Crore (10 Million) manuscripts.
- Establishment of Cluster Centers (CCs) & Independent Centers (ICs)
- Uses AI-integrated platforms for Metadata and National Digital Repository (NDR).

ABHISHA AI by Abhishek Pathak

II. GYAN BHARATAM PORTAL (LAUNCHED 2025)



- Digital Platform for Manuscripts
- Goal: Digitize & provide access to >1 Crore (10 Million) manuscripts.
- Under National Mission for Manuscripts (NMM).
- Establishment of Cluster Centers (CCs) & Independent Centers (ICs)
- Uses AI-integrated platforms for Metadata and National Digital Repository (NDR).

III. POLICY SHIFT: ASI & PRIVATE CONSERVATION (EARLY 2026)



- Public-Private Partnership (PPP) for Core Conservation
 - Transition from 'Monument Mitras' (amenities only) to structural conservation by private agencies.
 - Agencies empanelled as conservation experts.
- Mechanism: Using CSR funds via National Cultural Fund (NCF) in Tripartite MoUs.
- ASI retains regulatory oversight & DPR approvals.

	OLD	VS	NEW POLICY
Scope	Amenities		Core structural conservation
Execution	Solely by ASI		Empanelled private agencies